

PLSC 197 / SODA 110N: Social Data, Technology, and Artificial Intelligence

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Hello! Thank you for your interest in participating in the 2026 Penn State Exit Poll Project. During the midterm elections, I will be supervising a group of Penn State students as they conduct exit polls throughout Centre County. Along with conducting exit polls on Election Day, students will be invited to participate in an advanced seminar in the Spring that uses the collected data to conduct original analyses and present their work at undergraduate research events at Penn State. By filling out this interest form, you are not committing to participate, nor are you accepted into the project. If you have questions, please feel free to reach out.

Thank you for your interest,
Dr. Justin Crofoot
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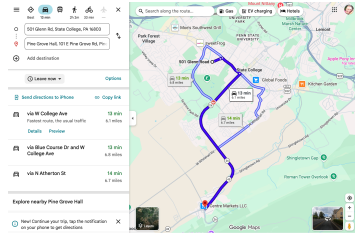
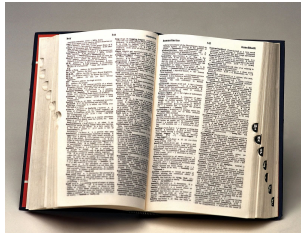
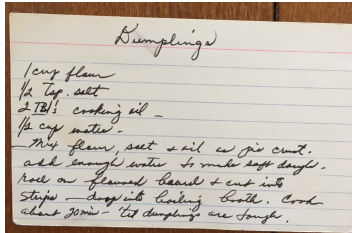
https://pennstate.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_0BeZiAym050AYaa

An algorithm is an unambiguous, logical, sequential, repeatable, finite set of instructions for carrying out a task.

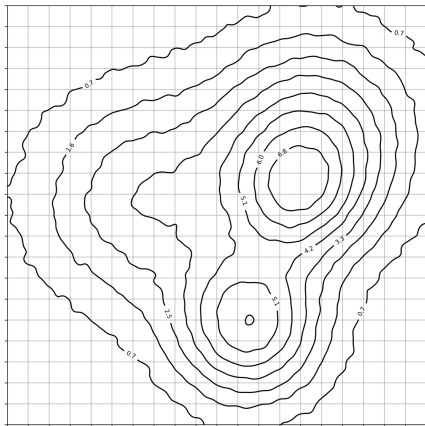
Algorithms:

- ...proceed from $\text{input}(s) \rightarrow \text{output}(s)$
- ...can be *deterministic* or *probabilistic*
- ...are technically different from *heuristics*

Algorithms: Examples



Make-An-Algorithm



Describe some algorithms:

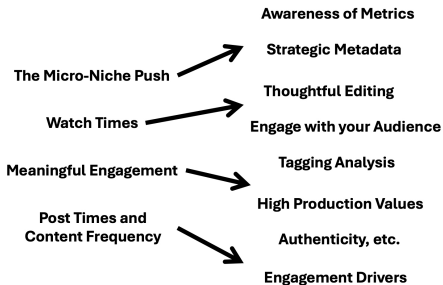
- “Brute force”
- Probabilistic
- Recursive
- Adaptive

Platform algorithms:

- ...operate *recursively, adaptively*, in *real time*
- ...shape *datafication*
- ...influence the user *experience* of the platform
- → affect user *behavior*, and
- ...generate user *emotions*

TikTok, 2025

The algorithm recommends a video and then learns from the user's engagement with the content. Newly posted videos are test-run by showing them to a small group of users, whose engagement with the video determines whether a video will be rolled out to a more diverse audience. Some of the key signals of engagement are video completion and interactions, or even likes, comments, and shares.



Bucher (2017): The Algorithmic Imaginary

“...the way in which people imagine, perceive and experience algorithms and what these imaginations make possible.”

Why is this important?

- An algorithm doesn't just affect content; it also affects beliefs (including about how the algorithm works) and emotions
- Motivated by emotions (fear, sadness, disgust, etc.) people begin responding on the basis of their understanding of how the algorithm works
- Those responses become part of the algorithm's data...

The “Algorithmic Imaginary” Cycle

